



▲ **RED ROOTS** Christian Louboutin, already making waves in the Paris fashion scene with his first store on Rue Jean-Jacques Rousseau, came up with the famous red-soled shoes in its studio

Sabya was fun. Our conversations were about food. We first met in Paris, and only discussed restaurants in Calcutta.”

Is he open to more such collaborations? “I am open to a discussion in general if something comes along,” he says, adding that one thing he has learnt in his 32-year career is to never waste time. “If you are having fun, or if you have a new passion, you will never waste time. But if you are doing something because others think you should do it, then it will be a waste of time.”

Having adorned the feet of global celebrities, if you ask the designer what makes for a pair of great shoes, he gives a cryptic, but an alluring reply. “A great shoe is one which has the possibility to appear and disappear. The shoe has the capacity to appear when looked at closely, but also disappear when worn by a woman, because it is all about the woman. The shoe is an extension of your body,” he says, adding that this was what was taught to his mentor by legendary French designer, Christian Dior.

When Louboutin launched his men’s collection, he opened a store on a quiet Paris street to gauge the customer’s response. He realised that his shoes were being picked up by musicians and actors,

and later athletes as well. “Basically everyone who puts up a show. It is about individuality. Those who have a singular mind, who are unique.”

In March 2021, Italy’s Agnelli family (the largest investor in Ferrari) acquired a 24 per cent stake in Christian Louboutin for €541 million (\$643 million), valuing the company above \$2.7 billion. At the time of the deal, the company had said the money would primarily be used for expansion, specifically in China, where the Agnelli family already has business interests. But it’s not only physical stores the brand is focusing on. Louboutin, himself an avid online shopper, is all in favour of online shopping. “I like to see and feel the garments [in a store], but then I order them online. It’s a pain to undress in a store,” he says. He has noticed something similar in his buyers. “They like to come to the store to try on the shoes, and then order them online.”

So, what’s next? Will he expand into categories such as home décor? He recently opened a hotel in a small town called Melides, in Portugal. But that, he says, is a one-off. “As of now, no. To be honest, I never give myself targets. I never say, I am going to be there in five years, or that the company would be doing this in 10 years. Mostly, I do things out of instinct and later realise that it just made sense.” However, he says the brand is going to focus on expanding the beauty business. It started with just nail polishes, but has since moved to lipsticks and eye make-up, with plans to focus on perfumes now. He will also look at developing the kids’ shoes line, and take it to more markets. It’s not available in India yet, and is unlikely to come here for the next few years.

In the ever-changing fashion world where styles come and go, Louboutin says the one thing that will remain constant is his trademark red soles. “I will be married only once, and it is already done. I am married to my red soles and I am sticking to it,” he laughs. All the more reason to paint the town red! **BT**

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